

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

Below is an extract from a local current affairs website:

Dogs: replacement children?

The birth rate in Hong Kong may be steadily falling but pet ownership and spending on pets is rising.

A recent report published by Akuba University, Japan, suggests that raising a pet dog can be the emotional equivalent to raising a baby in scientific terms. According to the report, the hormone oxytocin, which is released during moments of romantic or familial love, is also released when dog owners play with their pets. Some female dog owners say their dog-owning experiences have led them to decide on whether or not to raise children. In a significant 2012 survey, 16% of Hongkongers questioned said they would prefer keeping pets to having kids, a number which is seemingly rising.

Media reports estimate that it costs up to HK\$4 million to raise a child in Hong Kong. Owning a dog obviously costs less, but for some owners money is no question when it comes to the health and safety of their pets, easily spending \$23,000 a year.

Indeed, new businesses are thriving from dog-mania: whilst canine fashion is commonplace, Hong Kong now has restaurants that host dog birthday parties, salons for giving fashionable haircuts to dogs, and even psychologists who specialise in treating dogs.

Your group is giving a presentation on the increasing importance of dogs as pets in Hong Kong. You must discuss what to include. You may want to talk about:

- the reasons why many dog owners place so much importance on their pets
- the activities they do with their dogs in Hong Kong
- the advantages and problems that may arise from spending so much time with their dogs
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. What fun things can you do with a pet?
2. Would you like to work in a job where you look after dogs?
3. What things can you learn from having a pet?
4. Do you think students should keep a class pet at school?
5. Do you think some people spend too much money on pets?
6. Do you think caring for a pet and looking after a young child are similar?
7. What do you think about treating dogs as humans?
8. Do you think dogs can replace children?